

SACKING THE MANAGER DOESN'T WORK THE WAY YOU THINK





WHEN A TEAM STRUGGLES, THE MANAGER GOES

It's the default fix — in football, and in any organization. But teams in a slump often recover on their own, whether or not the leader changes.

So how much of the 'turnaround' is really the sacking?

1 THE NUMBER EVERYONE BELIEVES



+0.64

Points-per-game improvement in the 10 games
after a manager is sacked

This is the number that gets cited. It's also **misleading**.

2 WHAT THAT NUMBER HIDES



Both groups were club-seasons in an identical slump. The only difference: whether the manager was changed.

+0.64

SACKED

+0.53

KEPT THE MANAGER

Sacked



Kept



Struggling teams recover either way. Most of the 'bounce' isn't the new manager.

3 THE REAL NUMBER



+0.12

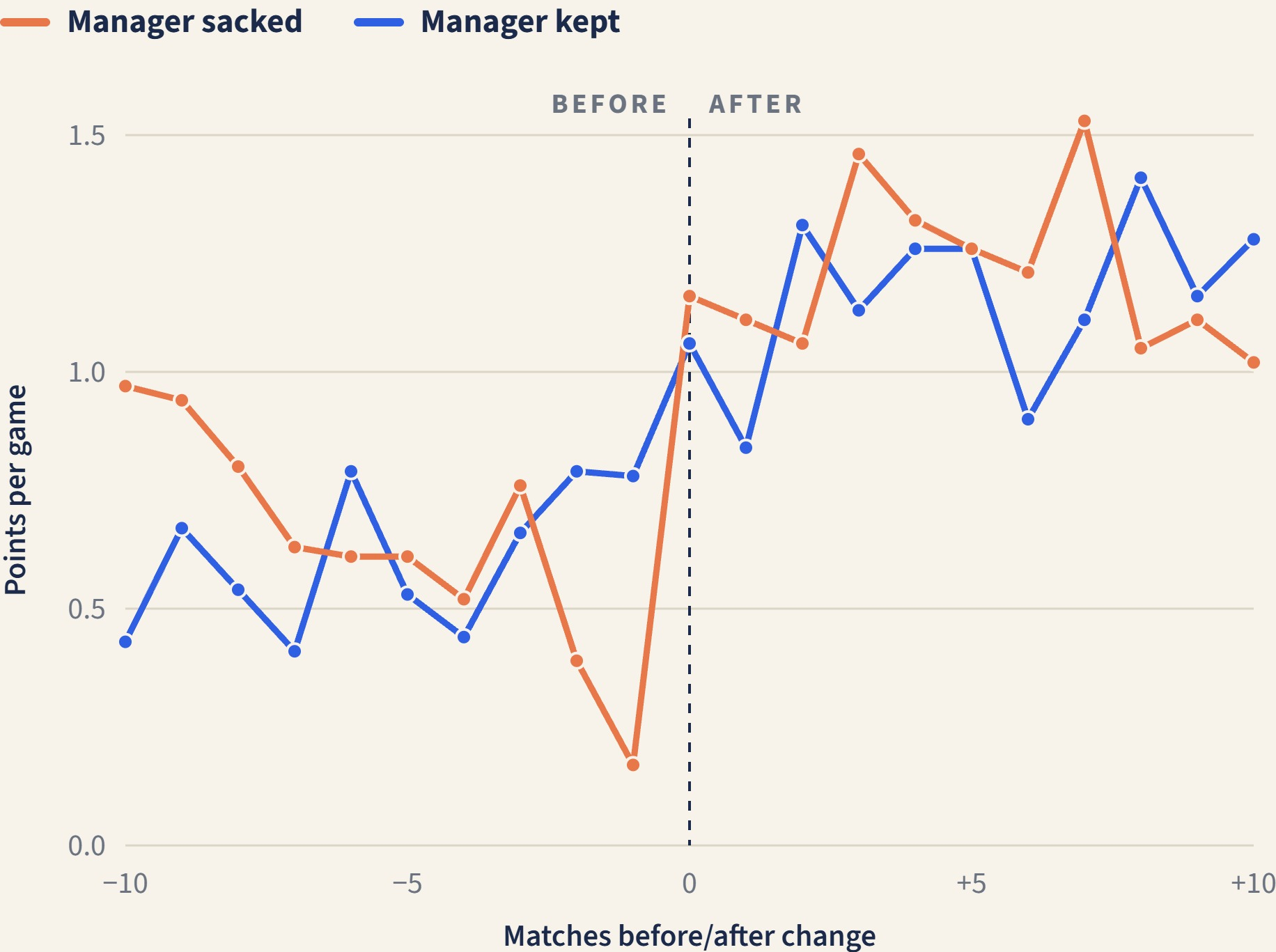
The actual gap attributable to sacking the manager
— and it's not statistically significant

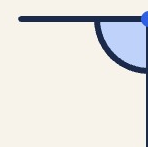
108 matched cases. $p = 0.06$.

THE BOUNCE IS AN ILLUSION OF TIMING



Clubs are sacked at their lowest point — so results can only climb from there. The clubs that kept their manager climbed just as much. The rebound is regression to the mean, not the new boss.





THE METHOD

154

In-season manager changes detected — Bundesliga, 2012–2025.

108 met the slump + matching criteria and were actually analyzed.

Matched comparison + regression analysis.

Robustness check: a shorter 5-match window shows a larger gap of **+0.23** ($p = 0.005$).



Tarif Hassan

AI & Analytics in HR | Solving People Problems across the Employee Lifecycle

Full analysis + code: github.com/tarifhassan27/manager-bounce